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Understanding Participation as a Response to Democratic Deficits

Governing mass societies is a complicated enterprise. As populations have grown, and become more interdependent, maintaining the democratic legitimacy of collective decisions has become ever more challenging. Increases in external constraints, especially financial, on representative government's capacities to govern both nationally and locally are well documented in the vast literature on globalization. Authoritarians and populists have capitalized on the inconsistencies in delivery of democratic goods by existing institutions. Citizens of traditional democracies increasingly react with a mixture of anger and despair when they feel the blunt consequences of decisions that seemingly were made without their obvious consent and often without much regard for their collective benefit or cost. Perhaps the most glaring example of this in modern times is manifest in the continuing fallout of the global financial collapse of 2007–08, now exacerbated by 2020–21's pandemic.

Liberal democracy in the 20th century provided citizens with the opportunity to choose rulers and to hold them to account as well as to form interest groups and pressure rulers to respond between elections. These equalities and freedoms when practised in large numbers were the great bulwark that democracy promised against decisions that would not work in the interests of the citizenry. Increasingly, those institutions do not appear to suffice, producing outcomes that large swathes of citizens recognize as neither democratic nor just. While support for the principles of democracy has risen worldwide, participation in the traditional institutions of government in democratic states (elections and political parties) has fluctuated and generally declined since at least the 1970s (Mair, 2013; Stoker, 2017). In response to this crisis of

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legitimacy, some democratic rulers have actively begun to invite citizens to take a more direct and ongoing role in political decision-making.

It is important to emphasize that this phenomenon of government actively seeking sustained and often substantial citizen input into its work is historically rare. For a whole host of reasons, people who have power, especially political power, do not normally voluntarily give it over to others. Notwithstanding the long history of direct democratic practices, particularly where town meetings or referenda are part and parcel of political culture, Mark Warren has identified an increasing worldwide trend towards 'governance-driven democratization' (2009). Democratic government has moved further away from the simplified ideal of responding to externally generated public demands such as campaigns, protests or writing to MPs. In response to crises of legitimacy, democratic rulers have actively begun to invite interest groups and citizens to take a more direct and ongoing role in political decision-making in domains that were previously the preserve of specialist administrators. Although they may take some inspiration from as far back as ancient Athens, many of these initiatives introduce a novel take on the appropriate architecture for democratic government. They are what Smith calls 'democratic innovations' – 'institutions that have been specifically designed to increase and deepen citizen participation in the political decision-making process' (Smith, 2009: 2).

This phenomenon of governance-driven democratic innovation has gathered pace since at least the early 1970s. A variety of processes, differently named, have claimed to help bridge the gap between governors and the governed. In some lauded cases these innovations have led to genuine changes in power relations. In others they have not. Some cases have mixed results. As scholars of power relations, political scientists ought to be both excited and sceptical about this phenomenon. The variance in cases presents the kind of puzzle that might justify the existence and maybe, if we can help solve it, even the wages of political scientists.

So how can scholars understand what is happening to explain changes in power relations? Especially in an emerging field, each individual research study must deal with the enduring analytical problem of many potential explanatory variables and few cases. Often, the primary remedy to this dilemma is to increase the number of observations as much as possible (Lijphart, 1971: 686; King et al, 1994). This tactic in the circumstances of PB research raises some significant but not insurmountable problems. In the build-up of rich case study literature and the development of several causal explanations for the outcomes of a democratic innovation like PB, an opportunity now arises. There is the

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potential for moderate generalizations in a larger systematic cross-case comparison of processes that have been institutionalized to differing degrees in different parts of the world. Casework and existing smaller comparisons suggest that causation is likely to be complex. Wampler, for example, suggests, 'successful PB cases depend on a series of factors converging to support the delegation of authority' (2007a: 159). Moreover, Peruzzotti has claimed that, 'democratic innovation is more likely to take place in a relatively grey area, where neither all of the significant variables promote change nor do all of them conspire against it' (2009: 58). Yet, at this juncture, a meaningful comparison of PBs based on conventional inferential statistical analysis is difficult to conceive. Despite the number of named PB processes now running into the tens of thousands, if explanations depend on complex conjunctions of factors and the goal is explaining how citizens gain meaningful control of decision-making, we do not appear to have the right kinds of data on enough cases on which to use correlational methods. Where those methods have been used, it has been mostly to predict health-related outcomes (Campbell et al, 2018). They do not (at least at the time of writing in 2020) appear useful for helping us filter signal from noise[1] in cross-regional studies of PB's democratic outcomes.

This book presents a new approach in applying QCA to provide a stronger assessment that clarifies and synthesizes the necessary and sufficient conditions for democratic deepening in cases of participatory policymaking. The QCA approach allows for an interplay between induction and deduction, united with a theoretical framework that is sufficiently anchored but comfortable with floating to identify novel theoretical contributions. I present a procedure that uses systematic Boolean logic when constructing research design in a way that has not been tried to such an extent before in the field of participatory innovation, to derive useful typologies and general explanations of how ordinary citizens gain control of political decisions.

Democracy and participation

Vast swathes of the world's population see democracy as desirable (at least as far as a common understanding of the concept can be assumed)

[1] A commonly used phrase in statistical analysis especially when dealing with high volumes of different data, which refers to overcoming data that is 'noisy' because it stops you identifying the 'signal' – i.e. the data that actually reveals what is going on in the world.

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(Stoker, 2017: 24). Ideology, social movements, economic growth and revolution have variously been responsible for shifting vast populations from subjects of leviathan rulers to sovereign citizens of democratic states. Yet, despite the many definite historical accounts of progressive instances, the sense remains that this is an ongoing, contingent and precarious venture. Any teleological understanding of a democratic project has been challenged in contemporary times. The expansion of civil liberties, political and social rights were crucial to advancing the democratic project in previous eras (Marshall, 1950). However, while this expansion continues in some areas, increasing retrenchment of liberties and decreasing participation in formal politics in other democracies reveals a fragmentation of democratic progress that can be seen to be at best, in the responsive phase of a dialectical progression, or worse still, the precursor to permanent decline (O'Tuama, 2009: 142; Stoker, 2017).

In significant contexts 'democracy' can be taken to mean everything from an abstract ideal type of governance where sovereignty is located with the people as a whole, to a formula of institutional arrangements that denotes a type of political regime, to a placeholder for a perpetual struggle with imbalances of power. Schumpeter famously defined democracy in very minimal terms as an institutional method by which elites compete for votes to rule over relatively uneducated masses (1942 [1995]: 269). For long periods during the 20th century, political theorists and those working within the emerging discipline of empirical political science accepted this wisdom. Nevertheless, since the 1960s, developments in empirical social science have shown that participation by citizens in the governing of their collective affairs beyond voting for representatives is possible and, very often, desirable (Dahl, 1961; Mansbridge, 1983; Bryan, 2004). Pateman (1970) has documented a long and rich history of more participatory democratic theory, which normative assertions that 'too much' democracy is undesirable do not withstand. With these empirical and theoretical accounts, democracy is imbued with far more potential. Yet, visions of what political equality could or should look like, and how it would be achieved, continue to be debated. And it remains an empirical question (with some competing evidence) as to whether, 'another world is possible' (see Michels, 1911 [2001]; Hibbing and Theiss-Morse, 2002; Santos, 2005; Pateman, 2012).

What is often missing from these debates about desirable and potential limits of participation in democracies, and the realization of democratic goods, is systematic analysis of a wider range of cases. We continue to produce more nuanced knowledge on specific processes and their

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context, yet few scholars have examined the contextual and structural features of political systems that could provide a better understanding of success and failure in empowered democratic innovation. If we want to change the world for the better, we need information on the context in which democratic devices are most likely to succeed or fail. Adoption of democratic innovations often takes place against a backdrop of perceived democratic failures. In advance of introducing PB and reviewing in depth the most recent scholarship on that celebrated innovation, it is worth providing an overview of the background in which democratic failures that necessitate reform have been identified.

Malaise and innovation

'It may work in theory, but does it work in practice?' is not an unfamiliar refrain for supporters of democracy to contend with. For those who wish to deepen democracy, there is a tension between grand republican ideas of citizens 'forced to be free' and 'acting in concert', as Rousseau and Arendt might have suggested, and the praxis of engaging those who are otherwise decided for in many difficult collective decisions.

Even for those who retain faith in existing democratic institutions there is much evidence of a 'democratic malaise'. Levels of traditional political participation have fallen, in terms of both party membership and turnout at elections (Stoker, 2017: 11, 33). In the UK alone, membership of the main political parties has fallen from over 5 per cent of the electorate in 1964 to a low of just 0.8 per cent in 2013 and 1.1 per cent in 2018 (Audickas et al, 2019: 5). While some may point to the increase in opposition party membership in the UK following the 2015 general election, its small scale despite the unprecedented salience of Westminster politics in those intervening years serves to reinforce the overall trajectory of decline. The trend across Western Europe is 'incontrovertible: party membership is in decline to such an extent that the dues-paying party member is in danger of becoming a dying breed' (Andeweg and Farrell, 2017: 77). While the longevity of cadre parties and the continuing establishment of those significant issue-based parties across the ideological spectrum show that the party is not quite over, mass mobilization and large-scale political engagement via political parties appears a thing of the past (Delwit, 2012).

The decline in voting is less terminal but still an important indicator of developments in the health of the traditional institutions of democracy. In the UK, evidence from the Hansard Society's yearly Audit of Political Engagement showed the share of respondents who said they would be

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certain to vote in an immediate general election falling from 51 to 41 per cent between 2004 and 2013. In the same period, respondents who claimed to be either 'very' or 'fairly' interested in politics reduced from 50 to 42 per cent. Yet these numbers have seen an uptick to 61 and 53 per cent respectively in 2019.[2] Actual turnout in the recent tumultuous elections between 2015 and 2019 in the UK has generally stabilized from a low of 59 per cent in 2001. However, we should caution against taking too much solace in plateaus. It is worth remembering that turnout figures in the 60–70 per cent range often mean that a minority of those affected by government decisions are voting, given registration barriers and voting restrictions on certain subgroups such as the young and migrants. An even smaller minority group is expressing a strong preference for the government, no matter the system of vote allocation. Hansard's Audit shows that this is certainly not the Britain of citizens imbued with a strong belief in their political efficacy that Almond and Verba (1963) encountered in their influential comparative study of 1963. The number of respondents to the Hansard survey strongly disagreeing that political involvement could change the way the UK is run hit a 15-year high in 2018. The British case is used here as an illustration, but there is plenty of evidence that the trend is replicated across the world (Dalton, 2004; Norris, 2011; Mair, 2013; Stoker, 2017). Across old and new democracies from the 1960s onwards, the number of citizens who have completely checked out of engaging with politics on a regular basis has increased slowly, but sizeably.

Not even the most radical participatory democrat would look to turn citizens of democracies into obsessed political anoraks. Some people have better things to do with their time. The trouble is that we are approaching a tipping point where disengagement begins to undermine the legitimacy of democracy. Anti-politics, alienation and support for populist interventions is reaching a worrying prevalence (Stoker, 2017). It is perhaps most interesting that in these same surveys, respondents who believed the system of government did not work well and could be improved 'a lot' or 'a great deal' rose from 60 per cent to 72 per cent. There appears a strengthening majority view that the institutions of government do not produce the democracy citizens would recognize.

In 1996, Arend Lijphart reminded the American Political Science Association in his presidential address of what he labelled democracy's remaining 'unresolved dilemma' – participation in these traditional

[2] The Hansard Society's annual reports, which began in 2004, are available at: www.hansardsociety.org.uk/projects/audit-of-political-engagement

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institutional mechanisms of decision-making remains 'systematically biased against less well-to-do-citizens' (1997: 1). It is likely that the growing trends in anti-politics since the mid-1990s see these groups even further marginalized. The explanation for the relationship between inequality and disengagement remains a puzzle. While aggrieved citizens ought to be most likely to want to express their dissatisfaction in a system of equal voting, their circumstances may serve to reduce their feelings of political efficacy to the point at which the grievance no longer motivates a positive response (Harrison, 2020).

Are the institutions themselves the root cause of this cycle of malaise? Lijphart advocated compulsory voting as a response, and I have sympathy with his ideas. Compulsory voting does force unheard political voices 'into the room', which, in theory, should produce responsiveness to those voices, but there is no clear evidence that compulsory voting provides a magic bullet for the problem where it exists. In lieu of, or as well as, providing a compulsion to vote in major elections, can we design new institutions to complement the traditional ones? Perhaps new designs can overcome failings, expose better the viable paths to complementary reform of existing institutions, or reproduce some of the democratic goods that no longer seem to be provided?

Towards the end of the 20th century, forthright critiques of existing democratic decision-making systems came from a broad church of participatory and deliberative democratic theorists (for example, Pateman, 1970; Gutmann and Thompson, 1996; Bohman, 1997; Young, 2000). At the superficial level at least, these criticisms share a common problematization of existing liberal representative democracy. They challenge the analytical focus on traditional forms of participation, such as voting, because those kinds of political participation do not engender significant and long-term engagement (Pateman, 1970), and only aggregate what some characterize as relatively uninformed preferences (Bohman, 1997). From this broad mix of tensions and critiques emerges a growing interest in democratic innovations that recast the relationship between political elites and citizens. Interest turns to the design of institutions that engage the disengaged and give political efficacy to those who have never known it in representative democracies. What does this look like?

Reform: when theories of democratic legitimacy meet the history of governing societies

While changes in the role governments play in governing has had an impact on accountability to citizens, citizens have, in turn, grown

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more educated and more critical (Beck, 1992; Inglehart, 1997; Stoker, 2017). Faced with a series of legitimacy crises, governors have been driven to respond. What is most interesting about the trend that has followed is that rulers have actively begun to create more direct roles for citizens in political decision-making.

Although the trend in governance-driven democratization has accelerated more recently, we can trace it at least as far back as the 1960s and to the US context. Against the backdrop of civil rights struggles, a new wave of citizen consultations were implemented in a putative effort to tackle some of the pervasive social and political inequalities in US municipalities, many focusing on the contentious issue of housing. They soon drew criticism. But salient criticism of those efforts at democratic reconstruction came not from traditional elitists anxious of engaging 'the great unwashed'; rather, it was founded on a scepticism that pointed to the dangers of superficial increases in participation, and therefore called for full citizen control of decisions (Arnstein, 1969). Arnstein's contention was that much of what passed for citizen consultation was an empty ritual aimed at consolidating elite rule. Consultations of this type can at worst be a mollifying 'incumbent democracy' that tranquilizes the genuine critical collective socialization that lies at the heart of ingenuity in free societies (Blaug, 2002). For Blaug, this engineering of participation by government must be met with a degree of scepticism as it may fundamentally be interpreted as a Bismarckian bid to protect the 'representative core' of the system. Yet, it is in response to some of these criticisms of derogatorily branded 'manipulatory' institutions that a new breed of institutions can be said to have emerged, 'institutions that have been specifically designed to increase and deepen citizen participation in the political decision-making process' (Smith, 2009: 2). Françoise Montambeault draws a useful distinction between autonomy from the state and autonomy within (2016: 35). While societies ought to value external critique of the state, they will want to work interdependently with the state apparatus to harness its power. We must remain sceptical and vigilant to processes and programmes that either set out to or otherwise end up co-opting citizens rather than engaging them on their merits. However, we should not deny the possibility, in fact the necessity, for governance-driven democratization to prosper.

The relationship between design and observation of these democratic innovations, and the critical democratic theory highlighted, is less straightforward than it may seem. Dalton (2004) has spoken of 'an unhelpful gap' in the literature between democratic theory and

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practice. Although the aforementioned critiques surely have had some influence on invention, the emerging field of academic study surrounding democratic innovations is more often characterized by a handful of determined democratic theorists catching up with practice than by experimentalists trialling their own grand designs (with some notable exceptions that attempt both, for example, James Fishkin's Deliberative Opinion Polls®). In an influential article, Fung recognized that 'political theorists and scientists would do well to learn from the emerging practice of mini-publics that are "creating instances of more perfect public spheres"' (2003: 338). Does what seems to work in practice work in theory, and how can empirical political science improve and refine democratic theories and vice versa?

Participatory budgeting

In the period from the 1600s to the 1800s 'No taxation without representation' emerged to become an enduring slogan for democratic revolutionaries, securing support for an idea and a movement that gathered momentum and changed forever how we understand legitimate governance. Yet, as regime change and universal suffrage extended out across the world in the 20th century, concerns about the persistence of injustices and inequalities in democracies have remained in focus. The declining membership of political parties and the re-emergence of populist leaders has signalled alarm for some of the most iconic democratic regimes (Mair, 2013; Levitsky and Ziblatt, 2018). In contrast, the continued emergence of participatory *democratic innovations* (DIs, or PDIs; see Smith, 2009: 1) – suggests a reformed and elevated democracy may be just beyond the horizon. PB fits into this wider historical picture, by bringing together the value of accountability for public spending with the move to more citizens participating more directly in governance.

Among these democratic innovations of the last number of years, the one that has excited governors, civil society activists and academics more than any other is participatory budgeting. Perhaps not since the acceleration of the cooperative movement in the last century has a participatory innovation seen such rapid diffusion. PB has been taken up in waves by a wide number of governments, as well as other public and semi-private decision-making bodies in Latin America, Europe, North America, Asia and Africa, and even in non-democratic states (Sintomer et al, 2008, 2010, 2013, 2016; Cabannes and Lipietz, 2018; Dias, 2018). PB had a long affinity with the World Social Forum and

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was promoted internationally throughout its networks of committed activists who recognized its potential to democratize spending decisions (Porto de Oliveira, 2017). It has been lauded by the World Bank as a model of 'good governance' and actively promoted by a small unit within the Bank (Goldfrank, 2012). It has also been promoted and supported by the United Nations (UN) through its HABITAT programme, by national governments from Peru (McNulty, 2011) to Portugal (Dias et al, 2018), and significant regional governments from Lazio in Italy (Sintomer et al, 2016: 76) to Scotland in the UK (Escobar et al, 2018). A recently published scoping review for the *Handbook of Democratic Innovations and Governance* by Stephen Elstub and Oliver Escobar (2019: 2) shows not only that DIs have rapidly become a significant field of scholarship, but that among studies of DIs, PB receives by far the most attention. Although PB has begun to wane in some areas (Spada, 2010), it continues to diffuse so rapidly that the total number of cases is still growing. In many places it has reached what Fedozzi et al call, with reference to Brazil, 'a time of maturity that has gone beyond experimentalism' (2018: 105). PB is almost certainly the most diffused democratic innovation since the 1990s, and we now have a good vantage point to assess it. So what is this idea, innovation or institutional design that so captivates?

PB can be defined at a minimum 'as the involvement of citizens in the budgetary decisions of a public body and labelled as such by the actors' (Talpin, 2011: 32). However, most definitions would establish a higher set of requirements to distinguish PB from the budget consultations that have traditionally been carried out with select groups of citizens or society representatives, such as incorporated stakeholders including business groups and trade unions.

There are dangers in definitions that are too prescriptive of levels of participation. Not everyone can or will want to participate in politics all the time – and that is almost certainly a mercy rather than a concern. Moreover, as PB has travelled, it has borrowed from different democratic traditions employing different selection mechanisms for participation. Nevertheless, Ganuza and Baiocchi are keen to point out that the origins of PB in open participation as opposed to strictly association-based advocacy had profound consequences in shaping PB as a vehicle for open governance over more protected forms of corporative-style bargaining (2019: 78). Yves Sintomer and colleagues, who have done more than most to try to bring some order to a concept that has diffused rapidly around the globe, provide the following six minimal criteria for PB:

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> [The process] … allows the participation of non-elected citizens in the conception and/or allocation of public finances and …. The financial and/or budgetary dimension must be discussed; participatory budgeting deals with scarce resources.
>
> The municipal level must be involved or a (decentralised) district with an elected body and some power over administration (the neighbourhood level is not enough).
>
> It must be a repeated process (one meeting or one referendum on financial issues are not examples of participatory budgeting).
>
> The process must include some form of public deliberation within the framework of specific meetings/forums (the opening up of administrative meetings or traditional representative instances to "ordinary" citizens is not participatory budgeting).
>
> Some accountability with regard to output is required. (Sintomer et al, 2008: 168; 2013: 3; 2016: 20)

The challenges in pinning down a definition of PB as the concept travels and the institutional innovation diffuses are returned to later in the book. The comparative approach I take offers a good overview of what is at stake in more open or restrictive conceptions of PB. My primary goal, nonetheless, is to identify the conditions within PB that explain citizen control of collective decisions.

Understanding the mix of conditions that explain success and failure in achieving meaningful citizen control of decisions across different circumstances is an important objective. PB has been lauded by academics, activists, intergovernmental organizations (IGOs), non-governmental organizations (NGOs) and many other governing bodies and agencies worldwide. Governments and the governed seem to think it is a good idea. Where PB has been successful it has given succour to democracy, re-engaging the disengaged and improving capacities and political skills through participation. As well as engaging people in performing democracy, PB has been shown to contribute to substantive outcomes including redistributing public funds to those most in need, counteracting clientelism and encouraging effective governance. However, where PB fails it risks increasing disengagement, strengthening clientelist or malevolent elite rule and increasing anti-democratic attitudes by diminishing any hope that ordinary people can make valuable contributions to collective decision-making.

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It is not surprising, then, that there has been growing academic interest in PB. Scholars from a range of disciplinary backgrounds have sought to understand its potential and to analyse its successes and failures. Despite this, Goldfrank summarized the state of the art after some 20 years of scholarship as follows:

> With some exceptions, scholars have either provided long lists of potentially relevant variables or attempted to extract lessons from one or more successful cases, making general conclusions difficult … recent research offers some clues as to why [PB] experiments are increasingly successful, yet a compelling framework that integrates actors, preconditions, and institutional design remains elusive. (2011: 24–5)

Some years later, systematic comparisons of many cross-national, cross-regional cases remain elusive (Wampler et al, 2018: 19, 50). Most of the scholarly work on PB has taken the form of single case studies or small-N comparisons of a handful of cases. There are several reasons scholars may not have been disposed to do more. For one thing, the rapid diffusion and adaptation of PB can make it appear a somewhat moving target, disincentivizing those who prefer to work with more neatly defined populations. To move beyond the impasse will require a degree of methodological innovation. Nevertheless, previous work does provide the research community with two invaluable assets: (1) much skilfully generated data describing cases of PB processes and their associated conditions; and (2) several competing hypotheses on the necessary and sufficient conditions for success and failure in participatory governance.

The large field of study dedicated to understanding democratic innovation that has emerged over many years is now (over)loaded with good case studies and small-N comparisons (where N stands for number of cases in a study). PB research often relies on ethnographic methodologies. This has led to a call for more systematic cross-case comparisons involving more cases (Smith, 2009; Ryan, 2018, 2019). In order to convince those with the power to do so to redesign, we need good evidence of what works, where, and how. Democratic practitioners will want to put into effect the conditions identified with success and avoid those identified with failure. The research presented in this book attempts to harness the lessons of the first studies of PB. My work stands on the shoulders of those case researchers, but I accumulate their work systematically to allow a more robust explanation drawing on more data across more cases.

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Why compare?

PB is not only of interest in this book because it can provide clear evidence of what works and when for those motivated by concerns for more participatory governance. Studying an emerging phenomenon like PB also provides the opportunity to ask important questions as to how comparative social science should seek to make sense of seemingly new, innovative and emerging forms of policy.

The era of governance-driven policymaking, where networks of actors must more often engage in competition for funding or other resources, has increased both the pressures and opportunities to innovate. This gold rush in institutional innovation requires some vigilance among political scientists interested in classifying phenomena and providing causal explanations of classes of phenomena. Social scientists are often attracted to understand cases because of the seemingly unique stories they tell. Nevertheless, if our focus is drawn to unique cases of participatory governance, it raises the question as to how we can build on an in-depth knowledge of a handful of cases to provide systematic evidence for causal theories (Ryan, 2019). This book therefore seeks to address practically the important issues raised when political reforms are recognized for their exceptional characteristics and political scientists wish to move beyond the lessons of one or two strong exemplars.

The research presented here is among the first to apply a QCA approach to the field of participatory governance. I bring together an approach and set of methodological tools at the cutting edge of case-based comparative politics with a field of study that is also growing exponentially. The result is new insight for those interested in the study of political participation and democracy as well as those interested in comparative research in the social sciences more generally. I assess the merits of QCA as an approach for cultivating insights into an emerging field of research. Each tool in the social science toolbox has different strengths and weaknesses in performing tasks. Scholars of innovation tend to work with concepts that are perhaps less easy to formalize because one of their defining characteristics is a departure from established norms. I learned that approaching PB research at this stage of its development provided advantages in understanding conceptual and methodological trade-offs that might benefit other subfields at similar stages of development.

Much like more established forms of modelling, QCA is a method that can provide parsimonious summaries of complex relationships that may signal relationships of cause and effect across large numbers of cases. Unlike more established statistical modelling techniques, QCA is designed to expose set-theoretic relationships (for example,

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relationships of necessity and sufficiency) among variables (Schneider and Wagemann, 2012). Researchers using QCA focus on research questions or hypotheses framed in terms of 'If X, then Y' rather than 'The more of X, the more of Y' (Thiem et al, 2016).

Any decision about research strategies requires the weighing of several factors relevant to the availability and structure of data. Early proponents of QCA would claim that the method can very commendably harmonize theory, qualitative data and quantitative data (Ragin, 2000), and this it is a particularly apt approach when a researcher is faced with a medium-N population of cases (Berg-Schlosser and Cronqvist, 2005). What those observers had in mind are opportunities for research where there exist more than a handful of cases and less than enough cases to avail of powerful statistical techniques for analysing correlations to identify probabilities when controlling for confounding factors. Ragin makes the intriguing observation that studies of more than a handful and less than a lorry-load of cases are unusual in social sciences (2000: 25). Despite its exponential growth in use among social scientists as well as other disciplines prior to my acquaintance with the method (see Thiem and Dusa, 2013; see also Rihoux et al, 2013), QCA's methodological scholarship has matured as I undertook this research. More recent methodological debates on QCA have argued quite convincingly that it is the underlying set-theoretic and propositional logic, rather than numbers of cases studied, that distinguishes it as a method (Thiem et al, 2016). Nevertheless, I was attracted to both the puzzle of how to cumulate systematic evidence beyond a handful of cases holistically as well as correctly test for necessity and sufficiency relationships that are relevant to PB scholarship. I return to what I learned about both of those issues regularly. I recognized in approaching the puzzle of what led to citizen control of PB processes that we had at our disposal rich data on a medium-N of cases (cumulating existing studies), and numerous competing causal claims, the majority of which, as I will explain, are set-theoretic rather than correlational. The PB phenomenon seemed fertile ground for QCA research. The QCA method is still maturing. This book shows how developments in comparative method apply to an emerging population of cases in PB, and provides an assessment of the effectiveness of the QCA approach in providing interesting insights in such a scenario.

Beyond techniques for policymaking and social science: wider significance

There are a number of important debates beyond municipal-level democracy and comparative social science to which evidence from

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a more systematic comparison of PB speaks. All relate to the proper place (if there is any) for political participation and the extent of a role for the 'ordinary citizen' in the governance of modern societies. 'Ordinary citizens' are most often taken to be citizens who do not take an established part in state decision-making as elected representatives or public administrators. The common use of scare quotes around the term indicates the distinction between ordinary and otherwise is not always easy to make. Its sense is often evoked in popular opposition to a 'political class' – those who have systemic influence and interaction with formal decision-making including politicians, senior civil servants, media and interest groups – what is, for example, sometimes known in the UK as the 'Westminster bubble'. It is easy for the same individual to identify with ordinary and not-so-ordinary depending on circumstances – populists are one example. Nevertheless, it remains a useful heuristic to identify those who have less or more constant access to formal democratic decision-making.

A first wider debate this research aims to contribute to is that which sets a standard for the need for democratic innovation at all. The question centres on whether participatory innovation can be a useful contributor to representative democracy and effective public administration. For some, democracy is justified by its ends and is 'not an end in itself', as only an elite few can make good decisions that truly benefit the collective (Schumpeter, 1942 [1995]: 242). Minimal safeguards in the form of regular(ish) elections can ensure competition among elites and negate reactionary mob rule. Democracy is simply a 'method' of cycling among elites and avoiding absolute tyranny. The problem with this account is that the method is not working, and we still desire the end. So the first debate is whether democratic innovations provide a solution, or do they open the door to folly or mob rule?

Opposing supporters of elite rule, others argue that opportunities for participation, even in between elections, can often be beneficial. If we assume that the standard for democratic decisions is that they approach as much as possible the benefit of all, well-designed opportunities to gather information from citizens and to allow them to respond to one another could improve rather than reduce the quality of collective decisions. Although scholars take the concept of 'deliberation' in a variety of directions, this is its most recurring contribution to democratic theory. Deliberative democrats are keen that a wider spectrum of discourses and experiences are brought to bear on a problem. They are interested in the solutions that come from the communicative rationality of bringing together and reconciling diverse perspectives. We may believe

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that there are good reasons for restricting elements of decision-making to experts and elected representatives (for example, on grounds of competence, or because the entire nation is an 'unworkable committee', as Schumpeter aptly puts it; 1942 [1995]: 261). However, it may be that we would like to provide decision-makers with complimentary institutions that harness what we might call 'proximal expertise'.[3] By proximal expertise I mean the innate expertise of the citizen who knows best how decisions currently and potentially affect them and others close to them. Schumpeter, in fact, is keen to recognize this expertise in his influential writings, although he sees no reason for why or how that kind of expertise should be brought to bear on matters of higher politics. There is a vibrant debate about the conceptualization of expertise in policymaking, but we have enough evidence now to show that firm restrictions on what counts as expertise can be as dangerous as denials of the value of established experts. Representation is often an inadequate route to including proximal expertise in decisions. One intriguing finding from the first PB in Porto Alegre was that citizens' expressed priorities for expenditure on public works differed from what their representatives thought their priorities were (Abers, 2000; Baiocchi, 2005; Santos, 2005).

If it can be shown that, at least some of the time, democratic innovations that are tried in traditional settings but in different contexts are recognized as effective modes of governing with positive outcomes for citizens, then it suggests that those who see elections and parties as the only effective institutions for democratic governance need to think again. Financial decisions are often considered the 'black box' of government, a realm of decision-making restricted on grounds of necessary competence to technocrats and seasoned professional politicians skilled in bargaining. For Carole Pateman, PB, as practised in Porto Alegre, provides an example of 'how central components of participatory democracy can be institutionalized successfully in what is conventionally seen as an expert, technical area' (2012: 10). And 'ordinary citizens' with little formal education have shown capacities to increase their budget literacy through participation in PB (Abers, 2000). An extension to the first debate, then, which speaks to a higher standard for democratic innovations, accepts that we may need democratic innovation, but asks what the conditions for successful democratic innovation and adoption of innovations might be. Ideal PB enables

[3] There is a good discussion of the different theoretical traditions that favour citizens' knowledge in participatory process in Sintomer et al (2016: 178–80).

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increased popular control over elements of budgets by institutionalizing citizens' participation in making spending decisions. The question the research presented here can answer that speaks to these wider debates is under what conditions might a more transformative and sustained citizen control of decision-making in political participation occur (and under what conditions is it negated)?

The next debate to which we might want to speak is whether participatory designs can be enablers for change at a more systemic level. There is much debate among deliberative democrats about the conditions for a 'deliberative system' (Mansbridge et al, 2012), and what role different institutions might play in that system. Gret and Sintomer, for instance, argue that participants in successful PB can act as a type of 'social vanguard', providing a positive example that can organically grow to involve those across the spectrum interested in reconnecting with democracy (2005: 92–6). For democratic innovations to have a systemic or cultural effect is a higher standard still, and one for which we may only be able to produce indicative evidence at this juncture. But by highlighting the conditions associated with successful outcomes across cases, I can pinpoint the cases and types of cases that speak to such outcomes. I am also better able to identify the puzzles that remain. This evidence may require closer scrutiny and fresh examination via other appropriate methodological tools such as combinations of process-tracing and network analysis to understand more systemic effects.

A final important debate revolves around what the appropriate methodological tools are for comparative political scientists wishing to cumulate rich, in-depth qualitative pieces of research that combine both common and disparate elements. Some of QCA's ambitions lie in providing at least modest solutions to the challenge of combining the essential knowledge of micro-processes that tell the rich stories of interesting cases with analysis that builds on this knowledge by providing robust systematic cross-case comparison. Yet only a few QCA studies have set out explicitly to cumulate existing and diverse qualitative pieces, and almost none have attempted to look at emerging subfields using fuzzy-set qualitative comparative analysis (fsQCA). The tendency has been to focus on established concepts – comparing welfare states, wars or political parties. My work therefore also looks to speak to wider debates about what value developments in set-theoretic analysis can add for comparative politics, and provide a test of the use of QCA where interesting questions are not easily answered using traditional methods of inquiry.

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Understanding democratic deepening

As innovative programmes of participatory politics have emerged and diffused over time, interested scholars have turned to fieldwork, and, in the first instance, to the construction of detailed case studies of types of innovation. Examples can be drawn across very different institutional designs, from popular assemblies such as town meetings (Mansbridge, 1983), community policing beat meetings and school boards (Fung, 2004), to participatory budgets (Abers, 2000; Baiocchi, 2005), and randomly selected citizens' assemblies (Davies et al, 2006; Warren and Pearse, 2008). These authors have broadly concerned themselves with recognizing interesting innovations that, on the face of it, warrant investigation because of their perceived or acknowledged exceptional potential for increasing democratic legitimacy – what case study researchers might call information-oriented selection of extreme cases (Flyvbjerg, 2006).

Beyond and because of this pioneering work, a more systematic comparative turn in the process of understanding these phenomena became possible. Following Fung's agenda (2003), I identify what it is that allows some cases of adoption of innovation to deliver democratic goods in the form of citizen control (and what negates such an outcome). Finally, I return to consider what the evidence of attempted participatory governance teaches us about both our theories of democracy and its practical advancement – what the value of democratic innovation is. It is these questions and the potential of new methods to provide new and important answers to them that lie at the heart of the book.

In the following two chapters, I provide an overview of the emergence of PB as a phenomenon as well as an object of academic scholarship. I show how social science has developed its inquiries of PB, explaining why systematic cumulation and comparison is not always prevalent, and why it should be in order to produce a scientific approach to understanding PB and other instances of participatory governance. I show how the best studies of PB have moved us in the direction of better understanding PB's potential, and reinforce the necessity of comparative research to overcome myopic responses to the problems facing democracy.

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